

▽ Columbia blasts off from the Kennedy Space Center



12 April 1981

FIRST SPACE SHUTTLE MISSION LAUNCHED BY THE US

Launched from the Kennedy Space Center, Florida, the Shuttle *Columbia*, carrying a two-man crew, pioneered a programme of reusable craft able to return to Earth after completing space flights. Over the next three decades, five such craft made a total of 135 missions, two of which ended in disaster.



◁ Columbia mission badge

1983

6 October 1981
Egypt's President Sadat is assassinated at a military parade

6 June 1982 Israel
invades Lebanon, laying siege to the capital, Beirut

23 March 1983 Ronald Reagan announces the "Star Wars" Strategic Defense Initiative



1911–2004
RONALD REAGAN

Famed as a film star, Reagan served as governor of California before becoming US president. A committed conservative, he played a major role in bringing on the collapse of the Soviet Union.



△ British troops "yomp" towards Port Stanley

April–June 1982

FALKLANDS WAR BETWEEN BRITAIN AND ARGENTINA

Following Argentina's invasion of the Falkland Islands, a British dependency in the South Atlantic since 1833, Margaret Thatcher's Conservative government dispatched a naval task force to reassert control. The conflict ended 10 weeks later with an Argentine surrender and the re-establishment of British sovereignty.